importance of restoring the status quo.[13] Thus, at various levels, the same point was being driven home.

On 4 Sep, Dr S Jaishankar, our Minister for External Affairs, met his counterpart, State Councillor and Foreign Minister Mr Wang Yi at Moscow, on the sidelines of the SCO meet. In this meeting, which took place only a few days after the actions of end August 2020, an agreement on a five-point approach to resolve the stand-off was reached. These were to 1) earnestly implement the important consensus reached by the leaders of the two countries, 2) strengthen communication on the ground, 3) avoid misunderstandings and misjudgements, 4) stop sending more troops to the frontline, and 5) refrain from unilaterally changing the situation on the ground, and avoid taking any actions that may complicate the situation.[14] In September itself, the RM, Shri Rajnath Singh, met his counterpart, Gen Wei Fenghe and sternly conveyed the same message, namely that China's aggressive behaviour was in violation of protocols, and that unilateral attempts to change the status quo would not be tolerated.[15] Naveen Srivastava had accompanied the EAM and was a party to the deliberations, as also present during the meeting between the Defence Ministers.

In all the meetings of the SHLMC held so far, while the Chinese side had their political commissar in attendance, we did not have any representation from the civilian side. The drawback was that our Corps Commander had to refer back on most issues, as agreeing to seemingly minor concessions in respect of Eastern Ladakh might have far-reaching consequences in relation to the settlement of the border issue as a whole. When I first broached this topic (of inserting an MEA representative in the delegation) with Northern Command, they were not too keen on this proposal, as they felt that it might dilute the

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